Purim 5784

I'm going to read you a long essay about פורים, covering many interesting facts you may not have learned before. The קשיא is a simple one: Is there a particular place in the מגילה, whether a פסוק or a word, that marks the exact point of ונהפוך הוא - the turnabout of the פורים story? Now, you might say that the מגילה explicitly states ונהפוך הוא. But that phrase only tells us that a reversal occurred; it does not indicate the precise moment when it happened. So, where exactly does ונהפוך הוא take place? Be patient with me - this is long, but the end makes it all worthwhile.

Through the miracle of פורים, Hashem not only saved the Jewish people from המן and their other enemies, but He completely reversed the situation, so the Jews switched from being subservient to their enemies to being their overlords. What's fascinating is that the turnabout is perfectly reflected in the מגילה. Each event that appears in the first half of the מגילה, depicting the desperate situation of the Jewish people, is exactly mirrored in the opposite situation, sometimes word for word, when depicting the joy of the ישועה in the second half of the מגילה. The trup frequently is even exactly the same. Here are a few examples. Number one: When אחשורוש agreed to allow המן to hatch his plot, the מגילה states (3:10) וַיָּסַר הַמֶּלֶךְ אֶת טַבַּעְתּוֹ מֵעַל יָדוֹ וַיִּתְּנָהּ לְהָמָן. Later when אחשורוש gives מרדכי the same ring after המן is killed, the מגילה states in almost the exact same words (8:2) וַיָּסַר הַמֶּלֶךְ אֶת טַבַּעְתּוֹ אֲשֶׁר הֶעֱבִיר מֵהָמָן וַיִּתְּנָהּ לְמָרְדֳּכָי. Number two: When the מגילה describes the writing and dispatch of the evil decrees in the first half, and the writing and dispatch of מרדכי's letters in the second half that counteracted the first ones, the same words are employed. You can look it up. Number three: After the promulgation of המן's decree, the מגילה describes the bewilderment of the Jews of שושן by saying (3:15) וְהָעִיר שׁוּשַׁן נָבוֹכָה, When it describes their elation at the news of the letters that מרדכי sent, it says in opposite words (8:14) וְהָעִיר שׁוּשַׁן צָהֳלָה וְשָׂמֵחָה. Number four: When describing how the Jewish people throughout the empire reacted in mourning to word of the evil decree, the מגילה says (4:3) וּבְכָל מְדִינָה וּמְדִינָה מָקוֹם אֲשֶׁר דְּבַר הַמֶּלֶךְ וְדָתוֹ מַגִּיעַ אֵבֶל גָּדוֹל לַיְּהוּדִים וְצוֹם וּבְכִי וּמִסְפֵּד שַׂק וָאֵפֶר יֻצַּע לָרַבִּים. Similarly, when the word of מרדכי's letters reached the same places, the מגילה states in word-for-word language, וּבְכָל מְדִינָה וּמְדִינָה וּבְכָל עִיר וָעִיר מָקוֹם אֲשֶׁר דְּבַר הַמֶּלֶךְ וְדָתוֹ מַגִּיעַ שִׂמְחָה וְשָׂשׂוֹן לַיְּהוּדִים מִשְׁתֶּה וְיוֹם טוֹב וְרַבִּים מֵעַמֵּי הָאָרֶץ מִתְיַהֲדִים כִּי נָפַל פַּחַד הַיְּהוּדִים עֲלֵיהֶם.

A rav named R' Mordechai Sabato explains that since each event in the first half of the מגילה has a corresponding mirrored event in the second half of the מגילה, there must be an exact midpoint, which represents the point of the turnabout, of ונהפוך הוא. To that end, he notes, there is no corresponding mirrored event for the public honoring of מרדכי, when המן leads מרדכי on the king's horse through the streets. Based on this, he explains that this is when ונהפוך הוא takes place. Expanding on this idea, it can be suggested that even within the story of the parade, we can focus it down even further. The two sides of ונהפוך הוא close in on each side when אחשורוש surprises המן by directing him to lead מרדכי through the streets. When המן details how he envisions the parade, thinking that he will be the honoree, the מגילה states (6:8-9) יָבִיאוּ לְבוּשׁ מַלְכוּת אֲשֶׁר לָבַשׁ בּוֹ הַמֶּלֶךְ וְסוּס אֲשֶׁר רָכַב עָלָיו הַמֶּלֶךְ וַאֲשֶׁר נִתַּן כֶּתֶר מַלְכוּת בְּרֹאשׁוֹ: וְנָתוֹן הַלְּבוּשׁ וְהַסּוּס עַל יַד אִישׁ מִשָּׂרֵי הַמֶּלֶךְ הַפַּרְתְּמִים וְהִלְבִּישׁוּ אֶת הָאִישׁ אֲשֶׁר הַמֶּלֶךְ חָפֵץ בִּיקָרוֹ וְהִרְכִּיבֻהוּ עַל הַסּוּס בִּרְחוֹב הָעִיר וְקָרְאוּ לְפָנָיו כָּכָה יֵעָשֶׂה לָאִישׁ אֲשֶׁר הַמֶּלֶךְ חָפֵץ בִּיקָרוֹ. Correspondingly, exactly two פסוקים later, when everything has turned around, and המן has to perform every detail for מרדכי, the מגילה states in amazingly similar language (6:11) וַיִּקַּח הָמָן אֶת הַלְּבוּשׁ וְאֶת הַסּוּס וַיַּלְבֵּשׁ אֶת מָרְדֳּכָי וַיַּרְכִּיבֵהוּ בִּרְחוֹב הָעִיר וַיִּקְרָא לְפָנָיו כָּכָה יֵעָשֶׂה לָאִישׁ אֲשֶׁר הַמֶּלֶךְ חָפֵץ בִּיקָרוֹ. In the middle of these two פסוקים there is one פסוק, פסוק י. This פסוק must be the central theme of where ונהפוך הוא pivots. In fact, the content of the פסוק clearly depicts the shifting of the favorite from המן to מרדכי, and it says וַיֹּאמֶר הַמֶּלֶךְ לְהָמָן מַהֵר קַח אֶת הַלְּבוּשׁ וְאֶת הַסּוּס כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבַּרְתָּ וַעֲשֵׂה כֵן לְמָרְדֳּכַי הַיְּהוּדִי הַיּוֹשֵׁב בְּשַׁעַר הַמֶּלֶךְ אַל תַּפֵּל דָּבָר מִכֹּל אֲשֶׁר דִּבַּרְתָּ. Taking it a step further, it is possible to narrow down the ונהפוך הוא in this פסוק to two specific words. What are the central words of this פסוק? מָרְדֳּכַי הַיְּהוּדִי! Until מרדכי's name is spoken here by the king, המן was still on top. You can see from this that the main point of this miraculous turnabout was מָרְדֳּכַי הַיְּהוּדִי, who did not waver an iota from his devotion to Hashem and the תורה, even in the face of המן's threats. We learn from here that מרדכי was the one who brought about ונהפוך הוא as a result of the תשובה he led the Jews in performing. As fascinating as this is, the pivotal point of ונהפוך הוא

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can be narrowed down even further. If פסוק י is the central point of the מגילה, and if the words מָרְדֳּכַי הַיְּהוּדִי are the central words of that פסוק, then the central point of these words is the pivotal point of ונהפוך הוא. The central point of these words, מרדכי היהודי, the last letter of מרדכי, and the first letter of היהודי, spell י-ה, Hashem's name. It was Hashem Himself, בכבודו ובעצמו, who was the ultimate force behind ונהפוך הוא. Another great example of Hashem being hidden in the מגילה in plain sight. Although the events of פורים may not have appeared obvious to the casual observer, since there are no open miracles, Hashem's name is hidden here exactly to point out that it was Hashem who brought about ונהפוך הוא. R' Aryeh Strickoff, who wrote this ספר, gives credit to R' Shmuel Marcus from our neighborhood in Queens, having alerted him and brought this vort to his attention, from R' Mordechai Sabato's ספר called הדסה היא אסתר. I thought this was a splendid piece of תורה from which we could all learn. Happy פורים!

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